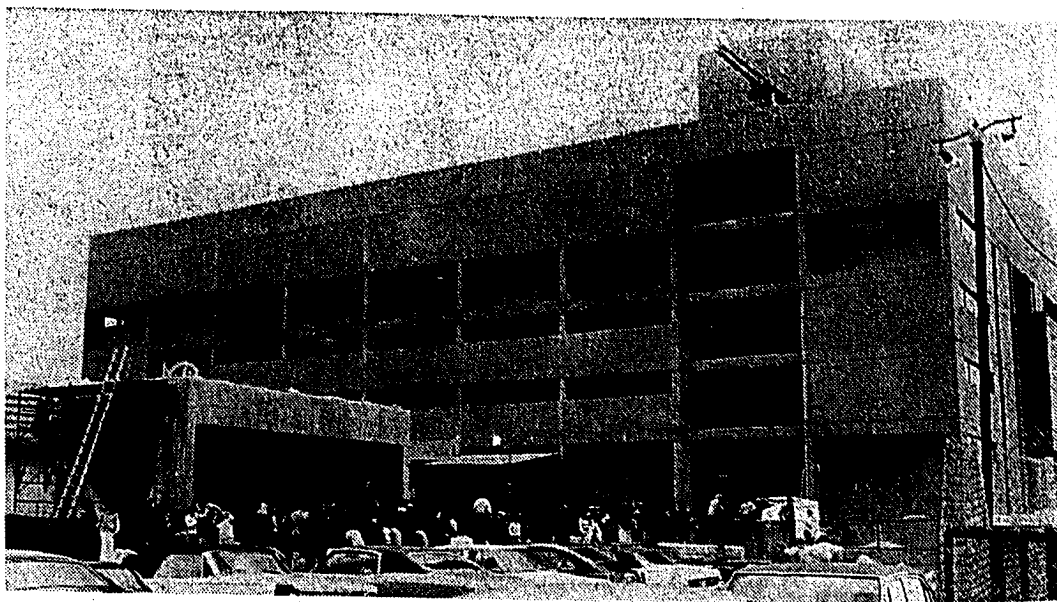




Boston's Aquarium, the one building public and pro-fession agrees is agreeable.

The architect as a threat

Every now and then — lately it's been working out to about once a day — a letter or phone call comes in with a comment on some aspect of the visual environment.

Nearly always the comments are negative. If anyone out there ever sees anything he likes, I don't get to hear about it.

One person, a designer employed by the city, called at night in a state of outrage over the fact that the Boston Parks Department was energetically destroying an old stone wall that surrounded the small, historic burial ground in Boston Common by submerging it under a new wall of concrete. (This "improvement" is now complete, and looks about as clumsy as you'd expect.)

Another nighttime caller said he'd made 40 calls that day to protest the demolition of the former Raymond's store on Washington street. Still another caller was trying to block a proposed super-high-density housing project for the elderly in Brighton. Another was concerned about a rumor that the Exeter Theater in Back Bay was for sale and might be demolished for a parking lot.

A Cambridge woman wrote supporting the referendum petition in

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that city, which proposes controls that would virtually halt all development; a Brookline woman was worried about a new high-rise in her neighborhood.

Most of these people seem to perceive themselves as lone voices in a wilderness, but, if so, they are voices that all seem to speak the same message. The topic of this column is architecture, and what's upsetting is the fact that, judging from the response of those who feel moved to communicate, architecture, in the sense of new building, is something that is most often perceived as a threat.

To anyone whose work is the design of new buildings, that's a sobering thought. Most architects probably don't let themselves come to terms with it.

Yet the sense of being threatened by new building isn't confined to cultural Philistines. Indeed, it's often strongest in the very people who are most sensitive to the best that architecture has to offer. In Boston, that best usually takes the form of neighborhoods rather than individual buildings, and what these people see and fear is the destruction of living neighborhoods by scaleless,

blank, unsympathetic new construction.

The notion that all new development is bad may be crazy — I think it is — but it seems to me that architects ought to come face-to-face with the fact that an awful lot of people really do tend to feel that way. A designer who fails to notice such a basic cultural dislocation is living a fantasy.

Except for the New England Aquarium, I'm not sure there is an important, recent, genuinely modern building in the Boston area that is generally admired both by architects and by the public. If anyone has a second nomination, I'd be delighted to stand corrected.

It's not just culture lag, though many would like to think so. Lots of people like modern films, modern painting, even (God help them!) modern music.

One area where the architects and the people who feel threatened can almost always find some common ground, however, is the issue of historic preservation. The long-awaited bill to strengthen the Boston Landmarks Commission is up before City Council this week. It deserves support.